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COURTSHIP IS BACK, BUT SOMETHING'S CHANGED

At a time of algorithm-swipe fatigue, people across generations are rediscovering that consistency, not chemistry, is the real flex

Sushmita Grewal

I was never supposed to be there. I had almost skipped that work meeting, but something made me go. Across the room sat someone who had been trying to meet me for nearly a year after first reaching out over Instagram. Neither of us had expected this to be our first meeting.

Afterwards, I opened my phone. There it was, a direct message. “Was it you?”

“Yes,” I replied. “It was me.”

What followed were weeks of what would once have been called courtship, but really wasn't. There were plans, long conversations, someone showing up because they wanted to. But beneath it was emotional inconsistency – hot-and-cold behaviour, the occasional ghosting (stopping

communication without any explanation).

Four months later, he gifted me an iPad after I casually mentioned that my old laptop had stopped working. It was beautifully wrapped. There was no practical reason to refuse it, but I did. The gift itself wasn't the problem, it was the timing. Despite moments of warmth, our conversations never seemed to arrive at the one question I needed answered: what were we? That contradiction made the gift feel impossibly heavy.

For a long time, I believed the discomfort – of always questioning where I stood in a relationship – belonged only to me. Then I began reporting this story. I spoke to people in their 20s who described modern dating as emotionally exhausting despite having endless opportunities to meet someone. I interviewed people

in their 40s who had returned to dating after long marriages and found themselves navigating a completely different landscape. I spoke to psychologists, dating-industry leaders, a novelist, and people who had quietly decided that consistency now mattered more than chemistry.

Again and again, they kept arriving at remarkably similar conclusions. What was considered cringe just a few years ago – being vulnerable about one's feelings, planning date nights instead of Netflix and chill, being upfront about expectations rather than ‘cool’ or indifferent, making custom playlists – were now sought after. People still wanted romance, they simply described it differently.

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ILLUSTRATION: HITESH SONAR



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PILLAI, 30, 180 cms, Entrepreneur. BE. Lives in Chennai. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448343

REDDY, 29, 178 cms, Engineer. MS in Civil Engineering. Lives in the USA. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448343

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MUDALIYAR, 25, 165 cms. Pursuing PGDM. Lives in Chennai. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448344

KURUMBAR, 27, 170 cms, Entrepreneur. MBA. Lives in Coimbatore. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448344

NADAR, 25, 165 cms, Entrepreneur. MA in Social Entrepreneurship. Lives in Chennai. Looking for a well-educated match from the same community. Contact: 6366448344

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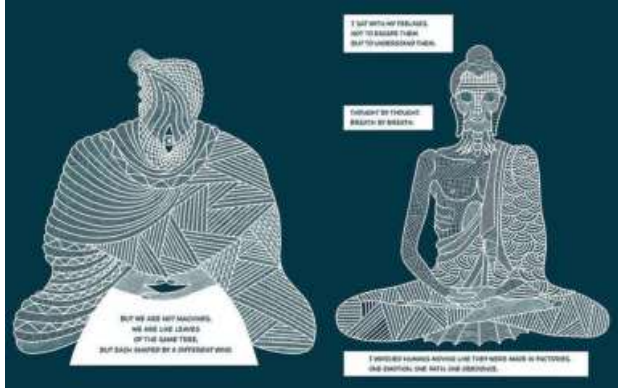
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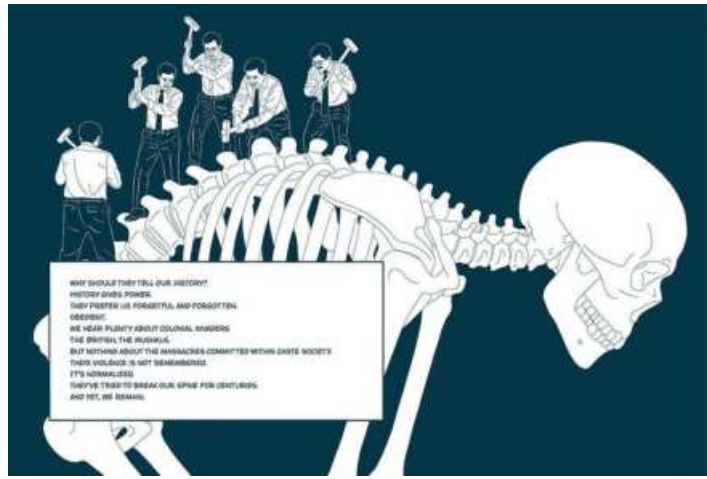
Siddhesh Gautam's artwork in *The Blue Book*, and (bottom) the artist-author. (COURTESY PENGUIN AND SIDDHESH GAUTAM)



Satwik Gade

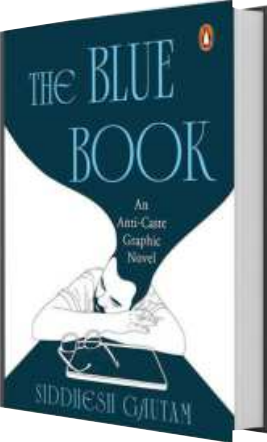
For nearly a decade, Siddhesh Gautam has been making his own gallery on Instagram. Under the name @bakeryprasad, his feed has become a vivid and restless archive of Ambedkar, Savitribai Phule, Jyotirao Phule, Ramabai and many others whose images circulate through the visual culture of Gautam's Ambedkarism. Gautam calls social media "the underground media of our time". His work there is brighter, more immediate and raw. With *The Blue Book*, his new graphic novel, he enters into a slightly different visual territory. It is quieter, more deliberate, and feels like Gautam has taken the visual language he has spent years developing and smoothened it to create the surface on which he writes his personal philosophical manifesto. The first thing one notices is blue. Instead of the black that usually gives a

graphic novel its outlines and shadows, Gautam uses a deep blue throughout. It is impossible not to think of the blue of Ambedkarite visual culture, but even as a purely visual choice, it works because the dark Prussian blue tones retain the depth and vividness of black but add a vibrant look to the page. Gautam's earlier writing on "the art side of Ambedkarism" describes



Wandering through minds and taking on animal forms, artist-activist Siddhesh Gautam dissects social justice and the role of memory in his graphic novel

ANTI-CASTE DREAMSCAPE



The Blue Book
Siddhesh Gautam
Penguin
₹799

comes with the artist exercising a studied minimalism that can sometimes make graphic novels feel like luxury objects instead of just comic books. But Gautam's pages are crowded with bodies, textures, faces and details. The shape and size of the book make the "page is panel" concept feel organic.

Then come the dreams. The book begins with Gautam searching for a way to belong beyond the country, the flag or the map, and finding instead a memory, a rhythm. In sleep, he travels across time and encounters those who have carried the anti-caste struggle before him: the Buddha, Ambedkar, Savitribai Phule, Guru Ravidas, Meerabai, Gail Omvedt, Fatima Sheikh and others. He does not simply meet them; he talks to them, asks questions, listens, argues and sometimes becomes an animal along the way – a crow, a deer, an ant, a white-rumped vulture, a cheetah. But the narrative truly comes alive in conversations with unexpected and lesser known people who populate his dreamscape.

There is something wonderfully strange about the animals Gautam turns into in this autobiographical journey through his dreamscape. Graphic novels have often used animal faces to

symbolically depict the plight of protagonists. Gautam does the reverse: he changes species but keeps his own face. The result is a dream of inheritance: a young artist wandering through the minds of those who came before, trying to understand what it means to receive a struggle, and what it might mean to carry it forward.

Engaging narrative
Gautam is interested in the lives that caste touches and the role of real and re-imagined memory. In an earlier article titled "Hyper allergic", Gautam has written that history has often been, for him, "a crime scene" – a place of "distortion, manipulation, and theft". Elsewhere, he writes, "Our aesthetics are political. Our memories are maps. Our dreams are blueprints for a better world." *The Blue Book* feels like a valiant trans-conscious attempt to draw those maps. The way Meerabai and Guru Ravidas and many others are unconventionally depicted becomes an effective companion to the philosophical counter-narrative in his dialogue and text.

The book does a wonderful job of discussing very difficult topics in a remarkably simple verbal and visual language. It is a good primer for young adults on issues of social justice. It is also told in a manner that younger audiences may find especially engaging. Public libraries and educational institutions would do well to include this book in their collections. But it is really adults who must engage with Gautam's ideas seriously in mainstream political conversations.

The reviewer is a Chennai-based writer and illustrator.

ONE FOR THE ROAD

What to read this month

Books about family, ancestors, creepy houses or lonely people – take your pick

Swati Daftuar

Family, and the feeling of belonging and togetherness it can provide, lies at the heart of many of the books in this month's reading list. Moving between literary and historical fiction, thrillers and horror, these titles feature works by familiar, much-loved writers alongside some newer names too. Together, they present a world that is at once intimate, fleeting and foreign.



The Haunting of Dr. Shamsi | Ayesha Muzaffar

In this collection of "unsettling tales", the title story begins with a baby born with six fingers in 1970s Lahore. The mother is certain the extra finger is scratching her of its own accord. From there, things get steadily less stranger. Loosely inspired by true events, Muzaffar's stories draw on family lore, superstition and the supernatural, with the old city sketched out vividly, gathering history and myth within it. The horror is slow and atmospheric rather than startling, making for a truly enjoyable read.

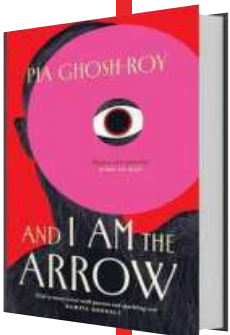
(PanMacmillan India; ₹499)



For Whose Dear Sake Our Fathers Died | Priya Hajela

"Countries are made up of stories. So are families," says matriarch Beant Kaur. Surrounded by her grandchildren, she reaches back through four generations of her family: to the Anglo-Sikh wars, the upheaval of 1857, British rule, and eventually the Komagata Maru. Hajela treats history as something handed down through families, rather than confined to museums and archives. The storytelling is direct and conversational, holding together the contradictions of patriotism, survival, pride and loyalty.

(Speaking Tiger Books; ₹599)



And I Am the Arrow | Pia Ghosh-Roy

Mishu's grandmother is formidable, acerbic and full of stories, many of which Mishu absorbs long before she understands them. Years later, when her life is coming apart in New York, Mishu is pulled back home when her grandmother falls into a coma. This debut novel resists tidy resolutions and expected arcs. The three generations of women who occupy its pages across Calcutta, London and New York contend with family secrets, birds, and a chorus of the dead who object to being called ghosts.

(Picador India; ₹599)



It Could Have Been Her | Lisa Jewell

The story begins with a lost dog, which leads the protagonist straight back to a house she narrowly escaped from 25 years ago. Now, Jane is forced to reckon with her past and dig up all that she has spent years avoiding. Moving briskly between characters and timelines, Jewell leaves breadcrumbs in just the right places, keeping us wanting more until we are led to a very satisfying ending.

(Century; ₹899)



Sophie, Standing There | Meg Mason

Sophie Pattison is at literary festivals attaching microphones to famous writers, which means she gets very close to people who mostly do not notice her at all. Until novelist Lilac Dunne comes into her miserable, lonely life, and changes everything for Sophie. Author Mason stays claustrophobically close to her heroine's mind, giving us a book that is funny, digressive and painfully sad without ever becoming performative.

(Bloomsbury India; ₹699)

(A monthly column on popular fiction.)

The writer is an independent journalist, editor, and literary curator.

Kiriti Sengupta

Having served as a narrative journalist for nearly 20 years, covering topics such as culture, nature, arts, and design, what additional value can Soumya Mukerji offer her readership with the publication of her debut poetry collection, *Cries*? Structured into three principal sections – 'Cries of Us', 'Cries of You', and 'Cries of I' – Mukerji holds up a mirror to us all. This mirror is subtly, silently, and resolutely positioned, challenging our perceptions. *Cries* invites reflection on socially pertinent issues and goes beyond that. The poems occasionally challenge us to take the appropriate steps forward.

The opening four lines of 'The Great Urban Circus' subtly introduce the

collection's core philosophy. Mukerji asserts: *the lion jumps into the ring of fire/ but the fox still outperforms/ the clown is cruel behind that mask/ he fools everyone but not foolishly*. The closing lines are even more compelling: *tightrope walkers fall and rise/ and everyone does the trapeze with perfect ease/ there's nothing to be scared of/ the net is everywhere, closed and safe*.

Mukerji emphasises on the word 'safe'. The prevailing socio-political landscape encompasses individuals from diverse backgrounds who, even when engaging in remarkable acts of protest, ultimately seek 'safety', because risking life for a cause is considered dated and not prioritised in this social media-driven era.

'Perfection is plastic'

Mukerji's concern arrives at a crucial juncture. In 'Seeker', she addresses her dilemma. *I*



Even as she writes of modern-day crises, the poet remains hopeful

went looking for words/ and worlds appeared/ I went looking for the world/ and the words disappeared. Finally, she realises: *you could have two homes/ or you could have three/ but none ever yours/ to have come too far/ too free*.

The poem immediately resonates with Salil Chowdhury's famous song, *Pothe ebar namo sathi/ pothei hobe poth chena* (Take to the street, comrades/ the road itself will show us the way). What does it take to be

called free? In 'Lockscape', Mukerji assures us: *there are neon glow-stars/ in that concrete sky/ a nightlamp rises golden yellow at dawn*. The poet seems hopeful and does not miss a chance to inspire her readers to yearn for a bright day ahead. She warns in 'Hanging In': *I hope you do not/ confuse your role/ with*

your whole. In the end, Mukerji urges, *for every soul that gives up/ kills a little of those that didn't*.

Although the poems in *Cries* are of myriad hues, they are sufficiently profound to be regarded as philosophical, and at times melodious when read aloud. Achieving this is no trivial accomplishment for any poet. Mukerji executes it with elegance. In her introduction, titled 'The Beginning', she contends, "Perfection is plastic. A poem, pure element." She substantiates her assertion by describing the collection as "The crises of our times." It is truly encouraging to hear an emerging voice that expresses concern regarding 'our times' and 'crises'. Mukerji's manner of addressing social issues through poetry is purely aesthetic.

The overall stylistic approach of the collection immediately brings to mind

another contemporary poet, Manu S. Kurup, who extended a similar appeal to readers: *The problem is that scholars/ mistake language for grammar/ ...Language is the tea seller/ asking where you vanished./ Language is the auto driver/ explaining politics (Tea and Tombs; 2026)*.

No wonder, in '1.20 am', Mukerji ponders: *the dogs/ barking/ seem like screaming humans/ or is it screaming humans/ sounding like dogs*, ending with a reflection: *it's the hour that morphs/ everything into the other/ isn't that how monsters are born?* Without careful observation, poetry feels hollow, like fake jewellery. Fortunately, Mukerji remains honest and invested in contemporary times.

The reviewer's Selected Poems (2025) showcases a career spanning 14 books of poetry and prose.

Afghanistan through the eyes of a hotel

Lyse Doucet's book offers an accessible but occasionally dizzying portrait of a resilient people



A crowded market street in Kabul and (below) Lyse Doucet. (GETTY IMAGES)

Sneha Pathak

Lyse Doucet checked into Inter-Continental Kabul for the first time after she landed in the city on Christmas day in 1988. As a BBC journalist who was there to report on the withdrawal of Soviet troops from the country, she had no idea how long she would be there. She ended up staying close to a year, and was a guest there many times in the years that followed. In *The Finest Hotel in Kabul: A People's History of Afghanistan*, which won the Women's Prize for Non-Fiction, Doucet returns to the Inter-Continental, popularly known as the Inter-Con, and uses the story of the hotel and its staff to narrate the history of a war-torn, yet resilient nation.

Golden years

The hotel opened in Kabul in 1969 when Zahir Shah was still the king. It was a sophisticated hotel in a city known as 'the Paris of the East' and was a symbol of the country's attempts to modernise itself and move with the times. During its heyday, Inter-Con was an emblem of luxury, of a lifestyle that most people of the country could not even dream of. With its fashion shows, music concerts, lavish parties, and finest food and drinks, it was far removed from the everyday realities of the nation.

However, the golden years of the hotel were short-lived. Only a few years into Inter-Con's existence, Afghanistan was pushed into a state of political uncertainty beginning with a coup against Zahir Shah. What followed was a period of political instability, as leaders came and went – or were killed – like people moving through revolving doors.

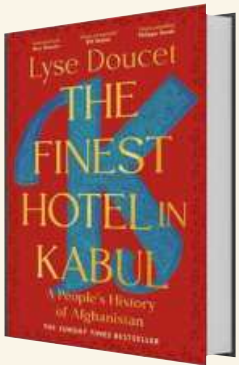
Doucet covers the history of the hotel and its staff, who continued running the place through tough times. The challenges they faced included the hotel's disassociation from the global Inter-Continental chain, lack of funds, working under the Taliban management, and attacks on the hotel, which resulted in the loss of many lives. In its determination to survive through the tough times, the hotel, in Doucet's telling, becomes symbolic of the Afghan people's resilience.

The narrative frame

The use of the hotel and its staff as a device to narrate the history of a country's people works well for the most part. Because the people through whom readers experience the hotel are ordinary people – from Sadeq, the sharp-dressing young man who dreams of studying in the U.S., to Hazrat, who joined the hotel in its early years – the hotel never becomes an elitist lens, even as it caters to the



The reviewer is an independent writer and translator based in Pune.



The Finest Hotel in Kabul: A People's History of Afghanistan
Lyse Doucet
Hutchinson Heinemann
₹999

elite. And like the people of Afghanistan, the staff, too, go about doing their everyday jobs – cleaning the rooms, preparing the food – regardless of regime changes, even as they constantly adjust to the orders and beliefs of those in power.

Doucet makes use of narrative non-fiction to bring to life the hotel's world and its people. This is at its strongest in the opening sections. For instance, her descriptions of the view from one of the hotel's three restaurants, Bamiyan Brasserie, which was the hotspot for casual dining, transports the reader there.

However, there are moments when this narrative frame feels shaky. The rapid changes of regime can make for a dizzying read, a feeling amplified by Doucet's compression of nearly 50 years of history into the narrative. The reader is often left navigating a maze of events unfolding at breakneck speed, retaining only a hazy sense of what happened by the end of the book.

This effect is compounded by the vignette-like sections focusing on the staff. To provide a rounded view of events, Doucet often hops from one staff member to another and back again. While this approach allows us to witness history through various eyes, it also prevents us from getting to know the characters intimately. Besides, Doucet's narrative non-fiction tends to draw attention to itself, especially in the latter sections, which feel almost novelistic in its portrayal of the people's lives.

The Finest Hotel in Kabul is an accessible entry point into the history of Afghanistan from the 1970s onwards. For the generations that have considered Afghanistan almost synonymous with the Taliban, Doucet's writing opens a window into a country long before they came to power. Her knowledge of the subject and her genuine affection for the people she writes about create a lasting impact.

Perhaps Inter-Con will regain its glory; perhaps it won't. Whatever the future holds for the hotel, Doucet's book ensures that, for her readers, Inter-Con will always remain the finest hotel in Kabul.



Birth place of Sree Narayana Guru in Chempazhanthy village, Kerala; (bottom) Shashi Tharoor; and Sree Narayana Guru. (S. GOPAKUMAR, PTI, THE HINDU ARCHIVES)

BEYOND THE SAINTLY IMAGE

Shashi Tharoor offers an accessible account of Sree Narayana Guru, but leaves the limits of his reformist approach underexplored

Anand Teltumbde

Among the many anti-caste reformers who shaped modern India, Sree Narayana Guru occupies a distinctive place. Revered in Kerala but relatively little known elsewhere, he led a movement that transformed the social and cultural life of a large section of the oppressed population while articulating a universal vision of human equality. In *The Sage Who Reimagined Hinduism*, Shashi Tharoor performs a valuable service by introducing Narayana Guru and his legacy to a wider audience. Written with empathy and clarity, the book succeeds as an accessible, intellectual biography of one of India's most remarkable social reformers.

A practical reformer

The importance of Narayana Guru lies not merely in the reforms he initiated among the Ezhavas of Kerala, but in the challenge he posed to the religious foundations of caste hierarchy. His famous declaration – 'One Caste, One Religion, One God for Man' – represented a direct repudiation of the Brahmanical worldview that sustained social exclusion. Tharoor effectively narrates the key moments of the Guru's life, especially the consecration of a Shiva idol at Aruvippuram in 1888, an act that challenged the monopoly of Brahmins over the sacred and asserted the right of the oppressed to religious self-determination.

The book also highlights Narayana Guru's role in inspiring social transformation through the Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana Yogam and related institutions. Tharoor is particularly effective in portraying the Guru not merely as a saint or mystic, but as a practical reformer who understood the importance of education, organisation, and social uplift. In this respect, the book helps correct the tendency to reduce him to a spiritual figure detached from the realities of caste oppression.

A broader frame

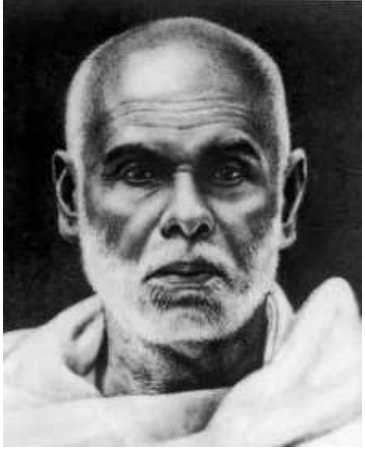
Yet the significance of Narayana Guru can be fully appreciated only when situated within the



broader trajectory of anti-caste movements in India. From Harichand Thakur's Matua movement in Bengal and Jotirao Phule's Sarvajanic Satya Dharma to the various Adi movements of the early 20th century and Ambedkar's eventual conversion to Buddhism, anti-caste struggles repeatedly engaged religion as a terrain of contestation. Since caste derived its legitimacy from religious doctrine and ritual, the oppressed could not simply ignore religion; they had to reinterpret it, challenge it, or abandon it. Narayana Guru belonged to this tradition. Like other anti-caste thinkers, he recognised that social emancipation required intervention at the level of religious consciousness. Unlike Ambedkar, however, he sought to democratise Hinduism from within rather than break from it altogether.

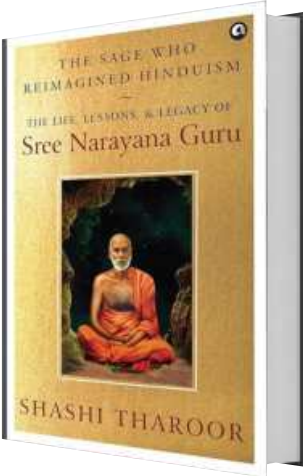
This raises one of the central questions surrounding his legacy. Was the reform of Hinduism sufficient to annihilate caste? Tharoor presents the Guru's universalist spiritual philosophy with considerable admiration, but is less inclined to probe the limits of a strategy that remained broadly within a Hindu framework. The contradiction is visible in the historical trajectory of the movement itself. Despite the Guru's universal message, the social base of the movement remained largely confined to the Ezhava community. Like many anti-caste movements, it combined universal ideals with the practical imperatives of caste-based mobilisation.

The book might also have



engaged more deeply with Narayana Guru's relationship to other strands of Kerala's anti-caste awakening, particularly the movement led by Ayyankali among the Pulayars. While the Guru challenged the ideological foundations of caste and promoted spiritual equality, Ayyankali battled against the orthodox for civil rights of access to roads, schools, public spaces, and economic rights. The two leaders shared a commitment to social justice, but represented different responses to caste oppression. Together they constituted complementary currents of Kerala's social transformation, one directed at religious reform and the other at civic and material emancipation.

Similarly, the Vaikom Satyagraha offers an illuminating perspective on Narayana Guru's social philosophy. While Gandhi viewed the agitation primarily as a campaign against untouchability and accepted a compromise limited to access to temple roads, Narayana Guru appears to have regarded such concessions as



The Sage Who Reimagined Hinduism
Shashi Tharoor
Aleph Book Company
₹799

inadequate. The logic of equality, in his view, could not stop at the roads leading to the temple; it had to extend to the temple itself. The subsequent Temple Entry Proclamation of 1936 arguably vindicated this broader vision.

Recovering a legacy

These observations do not diminish the book's achievement. Tharoor has written a lucid, engaging, and timely introduction to a thinker whose relevance extends far beyond Kerala. At a time when religious identity is increasingly mobilised for exclusionary purposes, Narayana Guru's attempt to ground spirituality in equality and human dignity deserves renewed attention. The book succeeds in recovering that legacy for contemporary readers and invites a wider national audience to engage with one of the most original social philosophers of modern India.

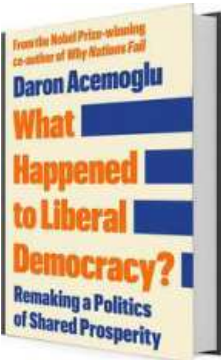
If there is a limitation, it is that the book occasionally leans towards celebration where a more critical engagement with the historical contradictions of the movement would have been welcome. Nevertheless, it remains an important contribution and perhaps the most accessible account of Narayana Guru available to English-language readers today.

The reviewer is a scholar, writer and activist.

BROWSER

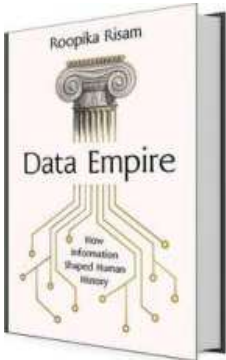
What Happened to Liberal Democracy?

Daron Acemoglu
Profile Books
₹2,605
Acemoglu offers a theory for rebuilding liberal democracy before it's too late. The question resonates in India, where debates about institutional erosion, majoritarianism and democratic norms are already front-page news.



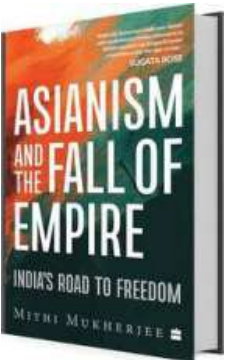
Data Empire

Roopika Risam
Torva
₹1,299
Risam traces data's journey from cave markings, clay tablets, and ancient record-keeping to censuses, colonial archives, mass surveillance, and today's algorithmic state. She makes the case that data has always been a technology of power.



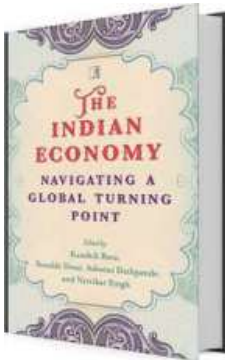
Asianism and the Fall of the Empire

Mithi Mukherjee
HarperCollins
₹640
Bringing together Gandhi's non-violent resistance and Subhas Chandra Bose's Indian National Army, the book reveals the wider Asian networks, political ideas and solidarities that shaped India's struggle against British imperial rule.



The Indian Economy

Ed. by Kaushik Basu, Sonalde Desai, Ashwini Deshpande, and Nirvikar Singh
Simon and Schuster
₹599 (Kindle)
This collection traces India's journey from the early decades of planning, through liberalisation, to the unresolved dilemmas of today's market economy, assessing where it stands and what comes next.



CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Modern dating
Courtship isn't making a comeback because people have become nostalgic for the past. It is returning because reliability has become unexpectedly rare. The generation that has learnt ghosting, situationships (romantic or sexual connection without clear labels), breadcrumbing (giving just enough attention to keep someone interested), and nanoships (short, light connections) is now discovering that what feels most romantic is clarity and consistency. They want someone to pursue them because 'old-school courtship' signals a person is willing to invest their time, in turn, isn't being wasted. The stats bear this out. Dating app burnout is at a record high, and paying-subscriber rates are on the decline: Tinder (4% year on year), Bumble (20%), and the like. In 2026, according to a survey by American market research platform SegmentOS, 53.3% of singles in the U.S. (including those divorced) have opted out of apps. They are looking, instead, at curated offline events. The scenario isn't too different in India. An early sign was a 2024 YouGov survey, which revealed that 66% of dating app users never meet their digital matches in person. Two years on, youngsters in metros like Bengaluru and Mumbai are ditching digital and looking for local events (curated and otherwise) to hang out with other singles.



Even when you've gone on a great date and you like the person, you still come home and keep swiping. You're trying to see what else is there. Is he the best that I can do? I often don't feel a connect because it just doesn't feel organic. You go through a lot of people, and everyone feels fungible [interchangeable]. Today, I think the art of meeting in real life and knowing how to start a decent conversation is lacking

DIVYA BALAKRISHNAN, 31
Stylist, Mumbai

came across] so they could connect with someone, anyone." But too many choices often make meaningful connection harder. She compares modern dating to standing in a supermarket aisle. "When you have hundreds of options, choosing one becomes

exhausting. You keep thinking maybe someone better is around the corner," says Khandelwal. The result is that attention becomes fragmented. "If I'm talking to five people, maybe everyone gets 20% of my attention instead of one person getting all of it."

This observation surfaces repeatedly throughout my conversations. People want intimacy, they simply struggle to invest deeply enough for that intimacy to develop. As Khandelwal puts it: "Everyone wants love, but not everyone is ready for commitment. Commitment requires time and effort."

Missing vocabulary of desire
Courtship has graduated from mere chemistry, one of its earlier foundations. Now, it looks for effort and deep connection: remembering something small that someone mentioned weeks ago; making plans and keeping them; checking in after a difficult day; giving someone your complete attention.

In a recent exchange, novelist Shobhaa De tells me about how she found herself explaining the vocabulary of romance to younger audiences. At *The Hindu* Lit for Life 2026, she was asked questions she never expected. "What exactly is a suitor?" Another audience member wanted to know what courtship involved. "Was sex included in the package?"

While the questions amused her, they also revealed something deeper. "The young seem confused with the vocabulary of desire," she says, explaining



Many have an unhealthy relationship with dating apps: they delete them, feel lonely, then reinstall them. Even people who find it exhausting keep going back because sitting with the discomfort of being single often feels worse. The emotional fallout isn't always dramatic: it's quieter, a gradual erosion of self-esteem and the ability to trust in a relationship

SHARMILA GANGULY
Clinical psychologist, Gurugram

that the language surrounding relationships has changed faster than the emotional needs themselves: "Romance never goes out of style," she says. "It merely mutates."

In her 2025 book *The Sensual Self*, De harks back to an older time, 40 years ago to be exact, when she and her yet-to-be husband enjoyed their first guava together in the Mumbai rain, after he decided to tag along for a visit to antique restorer Mahendra Doshi's atelier on Peddar Road. "We bought two guavas, one for each of us. After all, we didn't know each other well enough to share the fruit. His bite would leave teeth marks. So would mine. Most embarrassing. I didn't want to be seen with my cheeks full of half-ripe guava," she writes. Later, she reveals how he noticed she hated carrying handbags and frequently misplaced combs. So, he went along with her mother's advice to "purchase a small handbag to hold my comb [for her untamed hair that was always tangled]".

For De, the "biggest loss is sentimentality: the romantic gestures, flowers, compliments, love notes, shared music, gentle touches. Everything today is so upfront. The mystique is



missing". Her observation captures an irony of modern dating: never before have people shared so much of themselves so quickly, yet struggled to feel truly known.

When attention is romantic
For Srida Mitra, a 26-year-old media professional, the problem is what she calls performative vulnerability. "Constant digital interaction can create the illusion of closeness without actual emotional depth," says the Delhi resident. Endless texting and breadcrumbing



(Clockwise from left) Vidhushree Arya; Srida Mitra; Pranav Misra; Shobhaa De; a tarot deck Mitra got from a date after she mentioned the first deck should always be a gift; and a Sirf Coffee offline event. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

can simulate intimacy without building trust. "Emotional maturity and consistency matter to me much more today. I pay attention to how someone handles discomfort and conflict."

Over in Mumbai, Vidhushree Arya, 35, a content creator originally from Himachal Pradesh, has never used dating apps. She is wary of their promise of endless access and possibility, but where emotional fulfilment remains elusive. "What feels romantic today is attention," says Arya. "Somebody actually trying to know me as a person and remembering the smallest details about me. If I tell them I love a particular ice cream, and one day they remember and bring it because I'm having a bad day – that's romance, that's courtship."

'Giving more than you receive'
If Khandelwal described confusion, De, a disappearing vocabulary, Mitra, the illusion of intimacy, and Arya, a lack of emotional intimacy, for Pranav Kirti Misra, 41, the Delhi-based co-founder of ready-to-wear fashion label HUEBAN, it is the need to invest time. "In today's world, making time for someone is a very special gift," he says. "You are not distracted by your phone or the world around you. Your eyes are locked and you are completely present."

Misra remembers a long-distance relationship. Living in different places, they searched for a way to bridge the distance that

photographs and video calls could not. They exchanged a single item of clothing through the post as an innocent attempt to experience something uniquely human: how the other person smelled. It was a part of their courtship, a way of feeling a little closer to the other person. "Courtship has always been a part of love," he says. "It's just that] with the expansion of the Internet, people now know so much about each other before they even meet. Earlier, you had to discover someone through conversation and time."

One voice I keep returning to is that of Sagar Dwivedi, 26, an events professional from Madhya Pradesh, who is now based in Noida. He reminds me that despite all the discourse around dating fatigue, there are still people who simply want to love wholeheartedly.

When I ask him what he is looking for today, he doesn't hesitate. "I'm looking for a serious relationship and marriage. But people these days are like, 'Dekhte hain'." It's been over a year since his last relationship, and what he misses is expressing love.

He talks about how he travelled four hours by bus from Bhopal to Indore after finishing an event, just to meet someone he liked for an hour. Whenever work took him to another city – Ahmedabad, Jaipur, Kolkata – he would immediately search for train routes, buses and flights that could take him back to Indore for a quick visit. The relationship ended after she moved to London for her studies. "I miss doing those gestures. I want to give more than

receive. That's what courtship is."

IRL dates, please
What many have forgotten in our world of instant gratification is that courtship is a way to slow down, to discover what comes with love – that it can include longing, rejection, grief, desire, restraint and uncertainty. Radhika S. Bapat, a clinical psychologist from Pune, says, "We tried to outsource love. We thought algorithms could replace guidance, and short-form interaction could replace long-form intimacy." But while dating apps expanded access, it also normalised endless searching. "Our children are demanding that we turn back time," she says. "They're asking for spaces where relationships can grow organically." Libraries, bookstores, cafes, parks. Places where affection develops without algorithms deciding who appears next.

Interestingly, the people building the dating apps are describing the same shift as the people using it – to make dating more curated and more offline. Tinder has moved into IRL (in real life) dating through 'Tinder Events', which has hosted more than 60 gatherings this year. The League limits users to a smaller, curated set of daily matches and is investing in real-life experiences. Speed-dating and singles events are also seeing renewed interest.

For Anukool Kumar, Senior Director and Regional Head (India & Middle East) at The League, the conversation around romance has become noticeably more intentional.

"People still want romance, chemistry and excitement," he says, "but they're also thinking more carefully about whether a connection feels respectful and reciprocal."

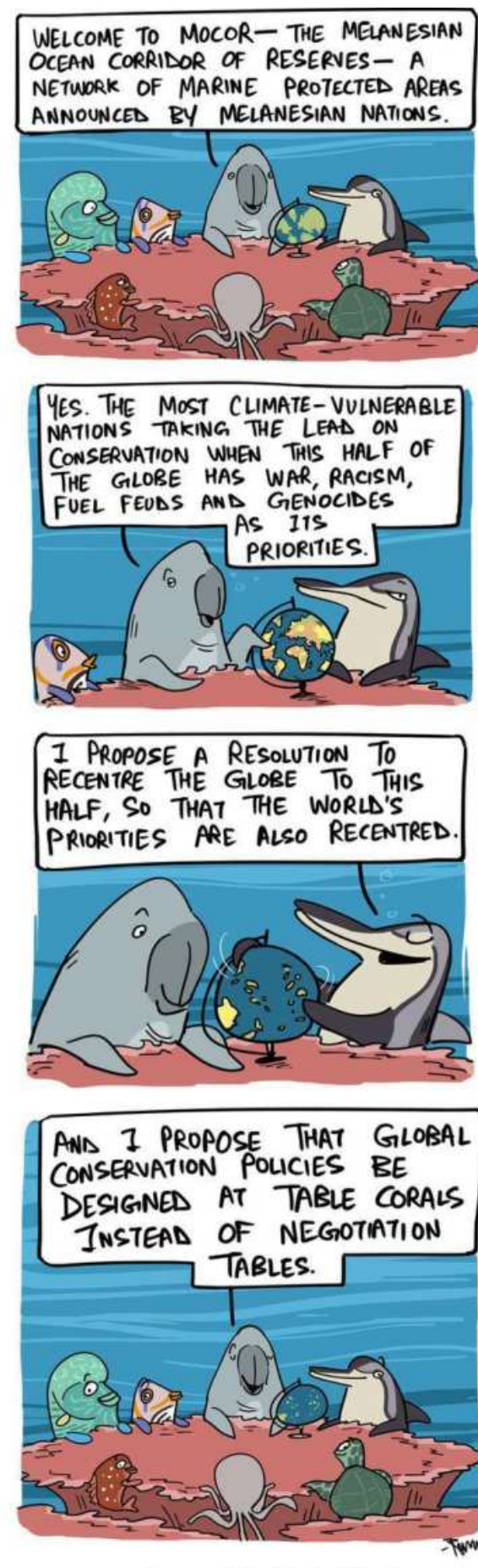
At Sirf Coffee, an invitation-only matchmaking service, human-led matchmaking is the foundation. Members are interviewed, matches are hand-picked based on compatibility and values, and the service facilitates an offline date. "People haven't fallen out of love with technology," says Sunil Hiranandani, its London-based founder. "They've fallen out of love with transactional dating." His clients want depth over velocity. "Nobody says, 'I want to be breadcrumb by six people simultaneously,'" he laughs. "A 25-year-old says, 'I'm tired of situationships'; a 40-year-old says, 'I value peace and consistency now'. It's the same emotion with better vocabulary."

Reporting this story has changed the way I understand courtship. I began thinking I would be writing about flowers and old-fashioned romance making a comeback. Instead, I found something better. In 2026, courtship looks like giving someone your full attention instead of dividing it between five conversations; checking in without disappearing; making plans and keeping them. It looks like consistency and emotional availability.

The fashion and culture writer explores people, identity, and contemporary India.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Shrabonti Bachi

Quite often, patients from the neuro clinic that shares its premises with Gallery Sumukha walk into the gallery's cavernous front room, filled with paintings and sculptures without knowing what the space is for. Premilla Baid, 73, the founder of the gallery which marks its 30th anniversary this month, finds these serendipitous drop-ins the best way for people to engage with art. The gallery doesn't seem incongruous in a mixed-use building, with a doctor's chamber and clinic out front. The doctor has been her generous landlord for decades.

The neighbourhood it's located in, though close to the city's central business district, isn't the typical upmarket area one associates with sumptuous art galleries. And yet, Wilson Garden has been growing into an art and culture hub with such spaces as I Shanthiroad, The Courtyard, and the Attakalari Centre for Movement Arts. This defines Bengaluru's art ecosystem in contrast to its arguably more sophisticated counterparts, Delhi and Mumbai – it is unpretentious, understated and a little scrappy.

Founded in 1996, Gallery Sumukha first started from Saida's home, then shifted to the Alliance Francaise building before relocating to its current location in 1999. Today, spread over 5,000 sq.ft., Sumukha is housed in the largest private gallery space in South India. Designed by architect Vikram Sardesai, it was built to accommodate large-scale installations, sculptures, and multimedia showcases that smaller commercial galleries of south could not host.

A gallery is born
Moving back to India after six years in Ireland, Baid was deeply inspired by art doyenne Sara Abraham's Kala Yatra. Self-taught Baid held her first exhibition for a charitable organisation at the Oberoi Hotel. "In those days [1996], we sold paintings worth about ₹5 lakh. That was a lot of money. Then it got into me,"



GALLERY SUMUKHA AT 30 SERENDIPITY IN WILSON GARDEN

From a shared space with a doctor's clinic to a three-decade legacy, this gallery mirrors the distinct, entrepreneurial spirit of Bengaluru's art scene

she says. "I don't know a word of art in the technical sense, I started the gallery out of pure passion alongside my medical practice."

Baid is careful not to call herself a curator but a gallerist. "Curators usually have technical training and an educational background in art. I just put shows together, relying on my judgment and understanding gained over three decades," she says. Initially funded by her own savings, the gallery has always been self-sustained. "Whatever money we make goes back into the gallery. Participating in art fairs is expensive. We may make some money here, go to an international art fair, and return without having sold anything, so it's difficult to turn



a profit," she says. Baid chose sustainability over aggressive commercial growth. The gallery's entries into Chennai, at her parents' home, in 2006, lasted around six years.

The early days
Until the 70s, Bengaluru didn't

play a prominent role in India's art world, says artist-sculptor Balan Nambiar, 88. "Karnataka Chitrakala Parishath held annual 'all-India' art exhibitions with works by regional artists... displayed at the banquet hall of Vidhana Soudha. In the 70s, Bengaluru

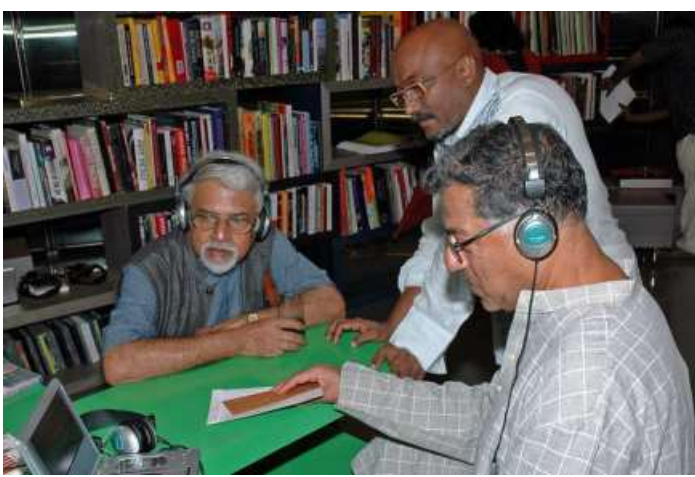
(Clockwise from left) Cop Shiva's archival print on paper; Gallery Sumukha founder Premilla Baid with artist K. Lakshma Goud; S.G. Vasudev, Bose Krishnamachari and Girish Karnad with 'LaVa', a travelling installation project (2006); Baid; G. Ravinder Reddy's relief sculpture; and M.F. Husain, Jagat Baid and politician T. Subbaram Reddy at Mansi Kirotskar's *My First Exhibition* (2003) at the gallery. (COURTESY GALLERY SUMUKHA)



then-nascent art world in the 90s. The 2000s-10s saw the gallery grow into a major commercial contemporary-art space and expand its international art-fair presence.

Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, chairperson of Biocon and a prominent art collector says, "Gallery Sumukha elevated the level of art galleries in Bengaluru. Before it came along, most galleries would be a bit of everything, from professional to amateur stuff. Premilla paid attention to the market, she organised events around artists and brought in a certain level of professionalism in curation that was missing from the art space in the city."

Rallying behind artists
Sumukha wasn't conceived simply as a place to sell paintings; Baid has been using it as a space for workshops (printmaking; sculpture), lectures and experiments. Artist Pushpamala N. says, "Sumukha has been encouraging new and experimental work and has been host to all our works in different media, installations and live performances. It has hosted talks and book releases. And recently, walkthroughs during those exhibitions attended by large groups of school students and art students. This major art space is on the bucket list of every visiting curator and artist."



had only two freelance artists: Rumlale Chennabasavaiah and myself. Most others were employed in government institutions," he says.

At the time, Kritika Gallery on St. Marks Road, run by Kausalya Dayaram, was Nambiar recalls, the city's only private art gallery, while Kala Yatra made a big impact in the city's cultural space. "Many galleries (Sakshi Gallery; Gallery SKE) later appeared and disappeared within short spans," adds the artist who's been a regular at the gallery since the beginning.

Amid government-owned (Venkatappa Art Gallery) and commercial art spaces (Kritika Art Gallery; Kala Yatra), Sumukha quickly garnered the reputation of being among the first 'serious' art galleries in Bengaluru's

Over three decades, Gallery Sumukha has mounted an estimated 230 shows, and worked with 100-plus artists. Its roster has included veteran Bengaluru-based artists such as Yusuf Arakkal and S.G. Vasudev to Vadodra-based Gulammohammed Sheikh, whose book of art prints was recently published by Sumukha, and K. Lakshma Goud, as well as major contemporary figures such as Atul Dodiya, Pushpamala N., G. Ravinder Reddy and Paresah Maity. City artist Ravikumar Kashi, whose career has explored the versatility of paper as a medium, has been nurtured by Sumukha since the 90s.

Crucial to the gallery's continued relevance has been its work with artists who have

drawn critical and commercial attention globally – veterans like Gulammohammed Sheikh to mid-career artists like Paresah Maity. The association with Maity in the South was crucial to Sumukha's own success. Baid, who's taken Maity to many international art shows, calls him the gallery's biggest "saviour".

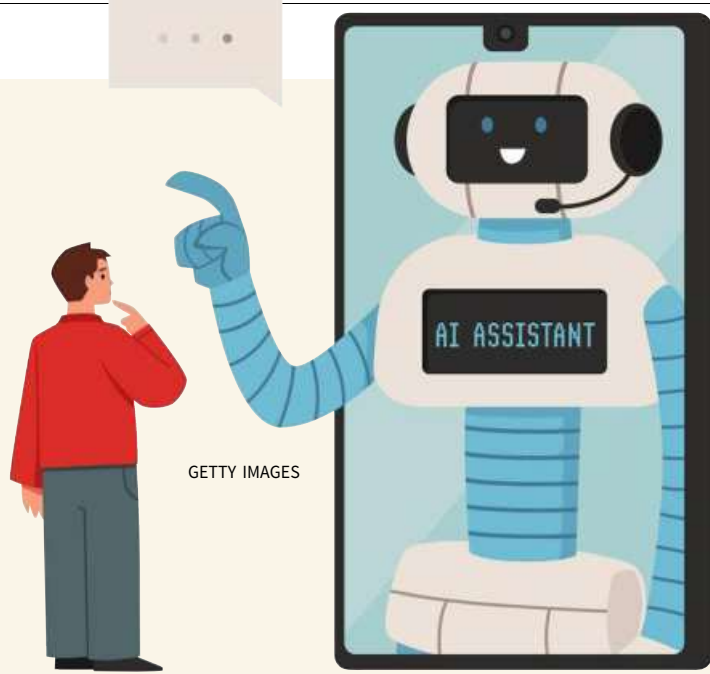
One of the biggest success stories of the gallery is Shivaraju B.S. aka Cop Shiva, a former policeman turned internationally recognised artist and photographer. "She [Baid] gave me my first solo show in 2012. You can say she found me – I was working as a coordinator at I Shanthiroad at the time and a friend asked me to meet her with my work," says Shiva. The rest, as they say, is history.

The road ahead
Bengaluru today has a much more flourishing art scene than it did when Sumukha was founded. Although the city is one of the three major hubs of the Indian art market, its IT wealth doesn't convert to art sales, which are a minor proportion of the overall sales in the country, especially when compared to the more mature markets of Mumbai and Delhi. "It is changing, but historically, there are two aspects to this: One, Bengaluru is a much younger city and the wealth is more recent... conspicuous consumption is much more in Delhi and Mumbai compared to Bengaluru, and the proliferation of galleries is less in the South compared to the North. The other factor is the growth of [geography-agnostic] online art sales," says Abhishek Poddar, Founder-Trustee of Museum of Art & Photography (MAP) and a prominent figure in the city's cultural space.

The gallery is marking its three decades with a rare solo show of Reddy's sculptures. "We don't do e-commerce, we don't think very far ahead in terms of technology. At art, that sort of thing. I stick to what I know best – finding good artists, young artists. I want to do better shows – that's it," says Baid.

The writer is an independent journalist based in Bengaluru.

- 1) What if 10,000 nuclear bombs exploded in one place at the same time?
- 2) What if 10 million nuclear bombs exploded in the same place 10 times?
- 3) How powerful will a uranium car be? Can it beat Lamborghini and Ferrari in a race?
- 4) I am not asking about a car that uses uranium as fuel. I am asking what if the car only is made of uranium?
- 5) What if I am wearing radiation-proof space suit? Will I still get cancer if I drive a car made of uranium?
- 6) Why can't you hear my questions properly – are you deaf?
- 7) What is speech-to-text transcription and also what if we fire a nuclear bomb from a gun?
- 8) So you are saying there will be no nuclear explosion if I fire a nuclear bomb from a gun?
- 9) If there is a fight between an anaconda and a pit bull, who will win?
- 10) If there is a fight between Vhagar and Tyrannosaurus, who will win?
- 11) Why are there no dragons in real life?
- 12) Why didn't evolution produce fire-breathing pterosaurs?
- 13) 'Manufacturing and carrying combustible chemicals would add weight and metabolic cost.' Explain this in simple language.
- 14) What if the dragon is using uranium as fuel?
- 15) Can dragons be used to drop nuclear bombs?
- 16) What will happen if I eat paper?
- 17) What will happen if I sneeze underwater?
- 18) Why did Tim Horton name his coffee shop Tim Hortons and not Tim Horton?
- 19) If there is a fight between King Cobra and Black Mamba, who will win?
- 20) What about the mongoose then?
- 21) If you drop a cat on the ground from a helicopter, will it land on its feet?
- 22) What if you drop a Black Mamba from a fighter jet flying very slowly?
- 23) What if you drop a Black Mamba from a



ALLEGEDLY

My son has questions

Nothing is off limits when Katta comes face-to-face with ChatGPT

helicopter flying at the height of a 100-storey building, and the Black Mamba falls on a bush?
24) What if the Black Mamba falls on a Golden Retriever? Who will die first?
25) How many ice creams can I eat in one day?
26) What will happen if I eat 100 ice creams in one day?
27) How to take part in World Ice Cream Eating Championship?
28) Is it true tanks don't have a windshield wipers?
29) Why fighter jets don't have windshield wipers?
30) Between Rafale, F-16 and Su-35, which fighter jet has the best AC?
31) Why doesn't the Russia-Ukraine war end?
32) Why doesn't the Iran-America war end?
33) If America is

India's friend, why is India afraid of America?
34) Which is more powerful – malaria mosquito or dengue mosquito?
35) Which is more powerful – malaria virus or dengue virus?
36) Is Plasmodium stronger than coronavirus?
37) If there is a fight between coronavirus and dengue virus, who will win?
38) What will happen if a coronavirus, a dengue virus and a Plasmodium infected the same person at the same time?
39) Why does Cyclops have only one eye?
40) How many babies have

been born with cyclopa?
41) Is there only one universe?
42) Who invented schools?
43) Which is the school in Delhi where teachers are not at all strict?
44) Which school in Delhi gives very little homework, most number of holidays, longest summer vacation, and longest winter vacation?
45) Why do so many snakes come out in the rainy season?
46) Can a snake climb to the third-floor balcony?
47) Can a snake climb to the 100th floor balcony?
48) What if we fill all service ducts and elevator shafts with mongooses?
49) Do mosquitoes bite snakes?
50) Do snakes eat mosquitoes?
51) If a mosquito drinks the blood of a King Cobra, will it die of the poison?
52) Why does the government keep cutting trees?
53) If humans have human rights and animals have animal rights, why trees don't have tree rights?
54) How many forests has India destroyed?
55) How big is 5 million hectares, and what happened to the animals and birds that used to live there?
56) What are the chances of humans becoming extinct?
57) If there is a nuclear war, which species will survive?
58) How many cockroaches are there on planet Earth?
59) Can cockroaches evolve into humans?
60) If somebody eliminated all life on earth, will life grow back?
61) Do you get bored of answering questions?
62) Then why do you keep saying goodbye when I haven't said goodbye?

G. Sampath, the author of this satire is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

THE INAT OF BEING DJOKER

A new documentary takes a closer look at Novak Djokovic, who is still world No. 5 at 39, making younger rivals sweat

Sanjukta Sharma

Novak Djokovic, the poster boy of sports longevity, turns 40 in 2027. At 39, his ATP ranking is No.5. Djokovic and his aura are still a daunting opponent; in an epic battle, he defeated World No.1 Jannik Sinner in the semi-final of the Australian Open this year. He has some of the most impressive statistics in the game's history: highest number of Grand Slam wins (24) and the longest time as World No. 1 in tennis history (a record 428 weeks). The Serbian tennis champion embodies longevity as the world understands it today: staying in the game longer, and fitter. So, a question that obviously haunts the tennis world is, "Will Djokovic retire soon?" Going by his momentum, that question is beginning to go stale, and as the new documentary *Novak Djokovic: The Wolf of Winter* (Amazon Prime Video) reveals, it annoys him: "If I can compete at the highest level, why should I stop?" Djokovic's arch rivals Rafael Nadal and Roger Federer are now

overseeing their own business ventures and playing golf. Director Jason Hehir recently said he came into the production of *The Wolf in Winter* in 2023. The documentary had been in the making since 2017. It isn't meant to be an all-encompassing biography, but a portrait of Djokovic today – in the winter of his career, when he's tapping into his extraordinary resilience, and facing retirement questions constantly. So, what makes Djokovic what he is? Turns out, it's *inat*.

Crashing the party *Inat* is a Serbian concept, which translates to a force of stubbornness when things go awry. When, in the 1990s, NATO bombed Belgrade, people gathered on a bridge wearing tags with the word 'target' written across them. It was a defiant message: 'come bomb us, you can't break our spirit'. Djokovic grew up there during that violent phase in Serbian history, and unapologetically owns his *inat*. Andre Agassi, who coached Djokovic in 2017 and 2018, the years leading up to his meteoric rise, explains how



that *inat* plays out: "For Novak to do the job, he needs fear or anger because with love or appreciation he loses his fangs." When he retired, hurt, from the 2025 Australian Open semi-final against Alexander Zverev, the Australian crowd booed him. He has famously used such booing to pump himself up in matches he

might otherwise have lost. Hehir's narrative combines beautifully shot footage at Djokovic's home with his family (wife Jelena, son Stefan and daughter Tara), footage from practice sessions and past matches, and from his childhood. The dreams of a financially struggling Serbian family

Novak Djokovic has the most number of Grand Slam wins and the longest time as World No.1. (COURTESY AMAZON PRIME VIDEO)

to make their oldest son a tennis star, the extraordinary self-belief it took to "crash the party" of the Federer-Nadal duo, the outrageous talent, the goofy imitator, the supreme athlete, meditator and tree hugger – it all comes together.

Channelling the wolf The world has appetite for the kind of documentary *The Wolf of Winter* is. What propels the narrative are details of how Djokovic achieved what he did, and its emotional centre is the now-popular idea that childhood experiences shape our default emotional responses. Sport was once simply guts and glory – a function of talent, hard work and a lot of protein; now it is also about navigating emotional blocks. Djokovic is his own therapist when he says, "When I started training in Germany at the age of 13, I became more mature, more stern, more stable, more of a man rather than a boy"; "You have to transform every part of your life outside of the tennis court to be in service of the tennis court. And that has consequences." Jelena emphasises how "vulnerable" and "gentle" Djokovic is, and yet "angry because

Djokovic embodies this Serbian concept, which roughly translates to a force of stubbornness when things don't go one's way

of unexpressed emotions that he has had to throw under the carpet". The couple repeatedly reminds us why no achievement is enough for Djokovic.

So, what is success in a sport that is so solitary and so much about confronting demons within? *Rafa*, the series on Nadal, sparked debates about mental abuse because it shows the Spanish champion's uncle-coach using brutal training methods. *The Wolf of Winter* says you can't escape from your childhood, but you can own it and heal from it.

Master of detox Djokovic was meant for longevity. His first ever coach, Jelena Gencic, his "tennis mom", introduced him to the benefits of listening to classical music and conscious breathing. "She trained me not for one, but several shots at winning Wimbledon," he says. In his 20s, he would tell his fitness coach Gebhard Gritsch, "I want to be absolutely fit when I am 40." How Djokovic eats, sleeps, hydrates, recovers and thinks, is the stuff of cutting-edge longevity science today.

He is known to integrate wellness and recovery practices from around the world and is the global ambassador and wellness advisor of Aman Resorts. Around the world, Aman properties now offer a three-day Novak Djokovic Detoxification Programme, curated by him. Three days of accelerated detox to master the Djokovic longevity template? Not really, as *The Wolf of Winter* shows us. It takes a world more.

The writer is a Mumbai-based journalist and founder of The Slow Fix (@the_slow_fix).

Bob Jones

Bidding the "other" major after Stayman to show a fit and slam interest is a common tool for today's experts. North-South looked good in the bidding but South dropped the ball in the play. He won the opening heart lead in dummy and led a spade to his king. When West showed out, he tried to cash two more hearts to discard a club from dummy, planning to give up a club and ruff a club. East ruffed

GOREN BRIDGE Overlooked East-West vulnerable, South deals

the third heart and led a club to West's ace for down one. South had an alternate line of play that is often overlooked – a dummy reversal. After West's discard on the first trump, the chance of a 6-2 heart split

became greater than usual. South should have cashed the king of diamonds, led a diamond to the ace, and ruffed a diamond with the queen of spades. Both opponents following suit to three rounds of diamonds would make

this line a sure thing. A low spade to dummy would be followed by another diamond ruff, this time with the jack. South could then draw all the trumps and concede a club, knowing that the opponents would not be able to cash a diamond. Had diamonds split 5-2, South would have to decide whether to continue the reversal and hope the opponent with the ace of clubs was out of diamonds, or lead a high club immediately to set up his club trick.

NORTH
♠ A 10 9 5
♥ K 4
♦ A 10 9 4
♣ 10 9 5

WEST
♠ Void
♥ 10 8 7 6 5 2
♦ 8 6 2
♣ A 8 7 2

EAST
♠ 8 7 6 3
♥ 9 3
♦ Q J 7 3
♣ J 6 4

SOUTH
♠ K Q J 4 2
♥ A Q J
♦ K 5
♣ K Q 3

The bidding:
SOUTH 2NT
WEST 3♣
NORTH 4♥*
EAST 5♥
SOUTH 3♣
WEST Pass
NORTH 4NT
WEST Pass
NORTH 6♠
WEST All pass
*Slam try agreeing spades as trump

Opening lead: Eight of ♥

QUIZ Easy like Sunday morning

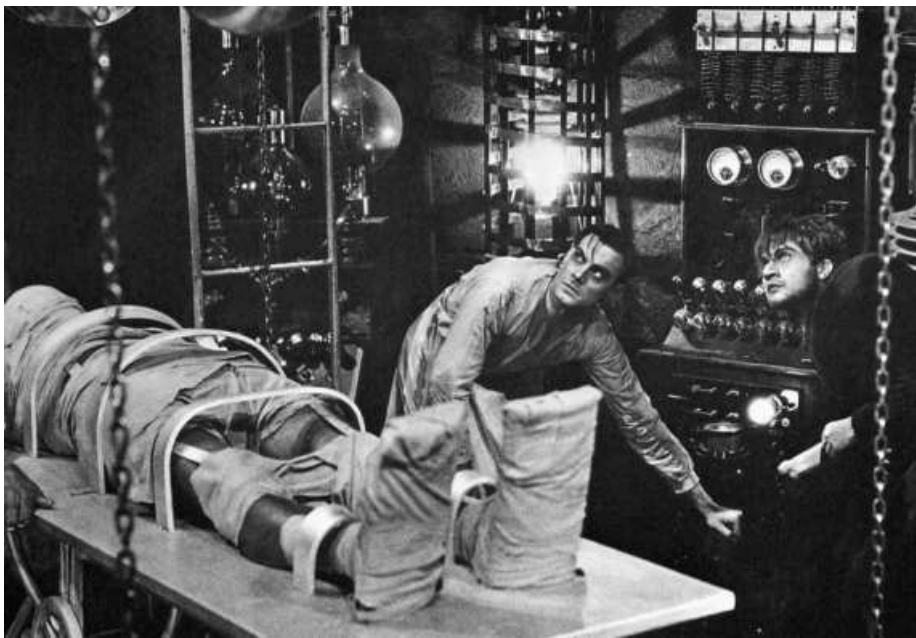
What has August 30 ever given us?

Berty Ashley

Born on August 30, 1797, Mary Shelley was an author who began writing her first novel at the age of 18. Inspired in part by contemporary ideas about electricity and the possibility of bringing inanimate matter to life, she wrote *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*. Published in 1818, the novel is considered an early foundational work of which popular literary genre?

On August 30, 1835, John Batman and John Pascoe Fawkner were among those involved in establishing a settlement in this Australian location. It was known by several names, including Batmania, before being officially named after the then Prime Minister of the U.K. in 1837. What is the city, now home to the Australian Grand Prix and the Australian Open?

On August 30, 1850, this place, which had been the seat of King Kamehameha III, was officially declared the capital of the kingdom. In 1893, the monarchy was overthrown, and in 1898, the territory was annexed by the U.S. Which city and state is this?



A still from the 1931 film adaptation of Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*. (GETTY IMAGES)

Born on August 30, 1871, Ernest Rutherford was a New Zealand physicist who has been described as the 'father of nuclear physics'. After winning the 1908 Nobel Prize in chemistry, he contributed an entry on 'radioactivity' to a world-renowned reference work. Which book series, found in libraries around the world, was it?

Born on August 30, 1930, this businessman turned 95 in 2025. Since 1956, his investment approach has helped make him one of the richest people in the

world, and he has a long history of philanthropy, particularly in the areas of children's health and education. Who is this legendary investor?

On August 30, 1963, a new recording format for audio was unveiled by Philips at the Radio Exhibition in Berlin. It used magnetic tape enclosed in a small plastic case and was named after the French word for 'little box'. What technology was this?

On August 30, 1963, a dedicated communications link was

established between the Pentagon in Washington, D.C. and the Kremlin in Moscow. Although it used teletype equipment and fax machines, its popular nickname referred to a colour associated with danger or warning. What was this system which we was also saw in the classic *Batman* television series?

On August 30, 1968, the Beatles released their first single on their newly established Apple Records label in the U.K. A fan favourite, the song ends with an extended coda featuring repeated vocals of the title and

'na-na-na'. What song is this?

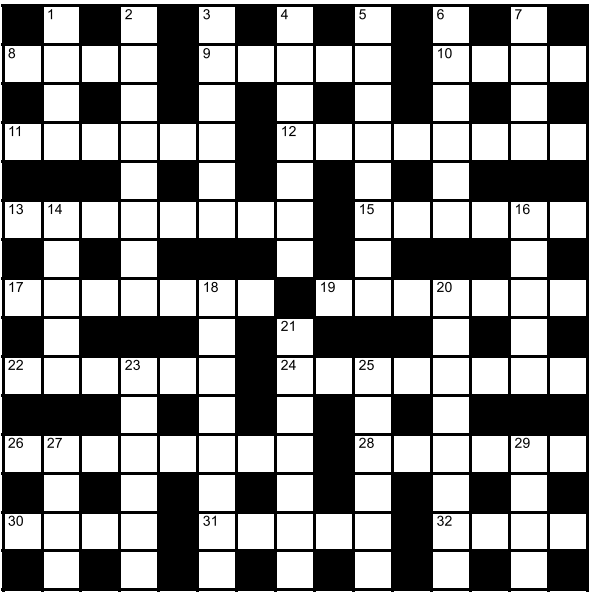
On August 30, 1987, this arcade fighting game was released. It introduced players to special moves performed using combinations of joystick movements and buttons, including the Hadōken fireball, Shōryūken dragon punch, and Tatsumaki Senpukyaku kick. What game was this?

On August 30, 2015, bestselling author Frederick Forsyth revealed a secret in his autobiography. The author of *The Day of the Jackal* disclosed that he had worked undercover for Britain's intelligence service for more than 20 years. Which organisation did he work for, one that sounds like something from one of his own novels?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

1. Science fiction
2. Melbourne
3. Honolulu, Hawaii
4. *Encyclopedia Britannica*
5. Warren Buffett
6. Compact cassette/cassette tape
7. Red telephone
8. 'Hey Jude'
9. *Street Fighter*
10. M16

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 71 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
8 Cause for bitterness in beers got from shop (4)
9 I hear recommendation to offspring to purchase animal (5)
10 Heard, "This is one kind of dog... Look!" (4)
11 Flowers from stars travelling around the Orient (6)
12 Break two knobs showing way to tie shoelaces (8)
13 Princess gets small requisition in mess (8)
15 One who hopes goes without Papa's jumper (6)
17 Excitedly digs in consuming morsel initially, a minute quantity (7)
19 Zulu leaves freezers built for refrigerated trucks (7)
22 Setter's little sister consumes egg, resulting in abnormal movement of pupil (6)
24 After one metre, cutting pliers creates risk (8)
26 Wrongly foretell, "It is without charge" (4-4)
28 Reach a river in spate (6)
30 He leaves hamper lying around in perambulator (4)
31 Place where a judge may woo? (5)
32 Special forces unit husband's cummerbund (4)

- Down**
1 Strange CPOs and policemen (4)
2 Space traveller adores it when travelling (8)
3 Badly treated a vehicle with editor (6)
4 International Organisation for

- Standardisation prohibits some lines on maps (7)
5 Ship around this time, garden equipment and piece of winter footwear (8)
6 Confide, "Pope is confused about Greek letter" (4,2)
7 Attend and defeat (4)
14 First Secretary General of NATO is dismayed to some extent (5)
16 Extraordinary role around beginning of raid for actor Flynn (5)
18 Teach instrument soldiers leave around beginning of combat (8)
20 Stronghold for lock? (8)
21 Wrongly figure about Pole and shoot weapon (4,3)
23 Susan, accompanied by French friend, makes sausage (6)
25 Around beginning of play, twisted tails and braids (6)
27 Rowers coarse at heart? (4)
29 Container for flowers from Java sealed (4)

SOLUTION NO. 70

A	D	H	O	C		B	O	W	L	E	G	G	E	D
B	I	U		O		A	N	O	R					
A	L	G	E	R	A	R	E	L	I	E	V	E		
S	H	A	R		R	M	A		E		R	S		
I	S	L	A	N	D		T	O	U	R	I	S	T	S
N	I	S		B	N	G								
G	A	G	A	R	I	N	G	L	E	A	D	E	R	
H														
D	E	T	O	N	A	T	O	R	S		C	A	R	D
F	I	S	H		F	A	R	M	S	T	R	O	N	G
E														
A	B	A	D	E	G									
T	C		C	H	A									
S	P	E	C	T	A	T	O	R		N	A	S	A	L

United in hilarity
and mirth

George Netto
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One of the commonest traits humans share is perhaps a sense of humour – fancied or real. No doubt, it originates from (and is nurtured by) our all-too-human need to laugh which, of course, distinguishes us from other animals whose lives are mirthless. And laughter, in turn, is a vital safety-valve that goes a long way in releasing all our repressed tensions, frustrations, and emotions, besides generating bonhomie.

Sans humour, or at least a modicum of it now and then, our lives will indeed be intolerably cheerless and dull.

Who hasn't noticed someone reading a book or magazine and grinning or chuckling to himself or even bursting into unrestrained laughter as honest humour hits home hard?

I remember a middle-aged man on a train years ago, engrossed in a slim book and oblivious of the other passengers. Suddenly, he exploded into an unabashed guffaw before realising there were others around. I caught a glimpse of what he was reading: a book of apparently risqué jokes by Khushwant Singh.

With its visual impact, cartooning has probably done more to enrich humour than anything else. I recall an old magazine cartoon of an irate homemaker fuming at her husband suffering from a nasty hangover after a late-night party. "I really don't see why your head should ache at all," she hisses. "You never used it last night!" I am yet to come across a better example of sheer biting sarcasm.

Then there was the jocular veteran tea planter who, in the course of his farewell speech at a planters' club in Munnar, wistfully recalled, "Some of the happiest years of my life were spent in the arms of another man's wife!" Then, as his audience gasped in incredulous shock, he added slowly, "She was my mother!" He received a standing ovation.

Humour sometimes turns up in the unlikeliest of places. Once I found this gem in a smelly public convenience whose walls, quite typically, were disfigured with smudges and blotches of peeling paint and plaster besides garish election graffiti. A wag had prominently scrawled an encircled message: "Here's an undiscovered Picasso masterpiece!" I couldn't help smirking in spite of myself.

As a guffaw-generator, my favourite was the irrepressible and uproariously funny cartoonist Mario Miranda; he seldom failed to leave one convulsed with laughter thanks to his unerring (and unsparing) eye for detail.

R.K. Laxman, of course, was in a class of his own as an outstanding political cartoonist. He parodied our foibles, unflinching and tellingly, sparing none and amusing everyone in the process.

Avisha Lubna Hameed
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Of late, I have been visiting a nearby public park to add some physical activity in my otherwise sedentary corporate lifestyle. Juxtaposed with the bustling hours of the city, mornings in the park unfold with a quiet rhythm. The air is unhurried, serene, and pleasant. It is one of the places where I allow my mind to rest. No podcasts, no urge to multitask – for a brief while, it's simply me and the park. Over time, I have found myself drawn to the people who inhabit this shared space. Here are a few personalities that stayed with me.

The DJs: Armed with smartphones, these self-appointed DJs curate the park's unofficial soundtrack. Golden tracks from the 1980s and 1990s reverberate across the eight-shaped walking track. Their audience is an ever-changing procession of walkers and joggers who take little to no interest in free music, but the conviction with which the music is played is admirable.

The laughing club: For this band of old friends, everyday is a reunion disguised as

exercise. Their morning walk is an excuse to exchange jokes, reminiscing youthful escapades, and the occasional reminder that they are, in fact, supposed to be working out. Just when the park settles into its familiar calm, an unexpected burst of laughter erupts, when they could be found seated in a circle, faithfully performing laughter therapy with the solemnity of a sacred ritual. Whether or not it burns calories is debatable, but it

certainly lifts spirits. Couch potatoes: These accidental athletes are apparently escorted out of their homes seeking good health. Clad in "athleisure", they dutifully start the timer for a rigorous session of doomscrolling, punctuated by an occasional chuckle at a reel, frequent yawns, and a few absent-minded stretches. Enthusiastic retirees: Whether driven by determination or an extrinsic push to bypass the pharmacy,

Love thy
neighbour

As India witnesses a growing elderly population and rapid urbanisation, healthy ties across the fence will be critical buffers for personal well-being

N. Rama Rao
ramaraon2014@gmail.com

I was awakened early one morning by the deafening noise of building materials being unloaded on the roadside opposite my house. When I requested my neighbour, who had ordered the stuff, to relocate it as it would hinder free movement of vehicles and pedestrians, he snapped, "It's not your road."

In another incident, when flood water entered houses in a low-lying area of the city during torrential rain, neighbours rushed to rescue an elderly couple who were caught in neck-deep water, unmindful of their own safety. These examples represent two extremes in the matter of neighbourly relationships.

During my recent visit to Singapore, I was struck not only by the high civic sense and discipline of its citizens but also by the various measures taken by the government of the city-state to promote a powerful sense of neighbourliness. For instance, its Housing and Development Board has built housing units in soaring tower blocks spread all over the city which serve as the primary platform for promoting civic harmony among 80% of its population. Units of varying sizes are juxtaposed on the same floor to prevent income-based geographic segregation. Under its ethnic integration policy, the Board ensures balanced representation of Chinese, Malay, Indian, and other minority races and prevent ethnic enclaves. The ground floor of these Blocks is intentionally left empty to host communal facilities such as benches, tables, and senior activity corners.

Top-down approach
The Singapore model is the result of decades of top-down government engineering, public education campaigns, and strict and consistent legal enforcement. The city-state has earned the sobriquet "Fine City", a nickname that highlights both Singapore's pristine and sophisticated environment and the hefty fines imposed by it to maintain public order.



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

In contrast, India, a much larger country, relies on a bottom-up and culturally organic framework rooted in philosophies such as *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* (the world is one family), group living (traditional *Mohallas*, family compounds, and group homes), and a structurally decentralised framework. As a result, most neighbourliness initiatives are driven by State governments, local bodies, and community organisations rather than by a single national programme.

Rural-urban divide
Another distinguishing feature of Indian society is the rural-urban differential in neighbourly behaviours. Rural life fosters deep interdependence. Neighbours frequently pitch in with farming, emergencies, and large tasks. Rural residents know all or most of their neighbours as populations are small and more stable.

On the other hand, due to high population density, urban attitudes centre on privacy and boundary maintenance. In apartment complexes of cities, residents have only a nodding acquaintance, meeting briefly only at meetings organised by neighbourhood associations or at planned events.

On the darker side, neighbourly relationships are disrupted frequently by clashing lifestyles,

boundary violations, and caste prejudices. Frequent parking disputes between neighbours in Chennai, for example, have escalated into a major civic issue due to the rapid rise of vehicle ownership and lack of adequate space. There have been reports of neighbours fighting violently over pet dogs that spoil shared areas or bite people. Tensions and public altercations often arise from recurring water-quality issues, pipe bursts, and supply disruptions.

These are only a sample of the innumerable disputes that frequently arise between neighbours. Resolving these issues requires understanding local housing bylaws, engaging in constructive dialogue, and utilising formal complaint mechanisms, when necessary.

As India witnesses a growing elderly population and rapid urbanisation, neighbourly relationships remain critical buffers for personal well-being. Recent studies have confirmed that in densely populated areas such as cities, online social networks of neighbourhood group chats, community apps, and digital boards effectively substitute for the traditional practice of having personal contacts with neighbours.

Yet, by and large, face-to-face interaction remains the preferred choice for neighbourly relations as it builds deeper trust and fosters mutual respect, and a keen sense of belonging that digital tools cannot provide. Moreover, due to digital divide, many senior citizens living alone would prefer that their neighbours personally respond quickly, when an emergency crops up.

Eventually, with rapid advancement and popularisation of digital technology, it is hoped that communities will adopt a hybrid network model to foster greater trust and collective efficacy.



In the digital landscape,
online social networks such as neighbourhood group chats, community apps, and digital boards effectively substitute for the traditional practice of having personal contacts with neighbours

they show up every day with zeal. No piece of equipment in the park escapes their attention. The air walker, waist twister, and cross trainer all put through their paces before they conclude their ritual with a generous sip of coconut water by the park. Spot a bewildered newcomer, they instinctively transform themselves into fitness gurus, dispensing generous advice whether solicited or not.

The young romantics: Rare presence in an otherwise senior citizen inhabitation, these couples choose the quietest spots where they could be spotted giggling, nudging, and at the same time, conducting a routine security check for not running into a familiar face. In a city like Chennai where privacy comes at a premium, the park quietly lends them a little of its own!

Politically minded: They are the park's very own news channel, broadcasting their digital diet from the day before. From Trump's tweets to the fluctuations of the stock market, they leave no stone unturned. A few rounds of jogging, and you could leave with political analysis, investment strategies and perhaps a novel business idea.

'Leave me alone' parents: they are the overwhelmed parents trying to find solace. The moment their tiny tots find a playmate, the mission is accomplished – as they indulge in their quietme-time. For them the park is a free day-care arrangement.

The reel-fluencers: For them, the park is an outdoor film studio. Interrupt their frame, you might earn a disapproving glare. By the time they have perfected a 10-second reel, you have probably completed an entire lap.

Couple therapy: These are the veteran couples who religiously begin their mornings with a leisurely walk. More often than not, the husband strides forward, while the wife somehow keeps up with his pace and conversation. Their walks are paused only for an occasional video call from their grandchildren.

The athletes: Quiet, focused, and fiercely determined, for them the park is an open-air training ground. Every sprint, stretch, and drill is executed with purpose.

Conversation for them is just another distraction. Nevertheless, these personalities are what make my mornings engaging.

Personalities of the park

The routine morning walk is enriched with an array of characters



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The cover story rightly cautions against allowing technology to weaken independent thinking. ('AI and the lines I won't cross'; Aug. 23) AI can handle repetitive tasks and save time, but creativity, judgment and responsibility must remain human. Schools and workplaces should teach responsible use, including fact-checking and attribution.

A. Myilsami

The concern is not regarding the use of AI in work. It is about AI in the creative process. Anyone who has used AI knows its language, its tendency to offer more than what is asked for. Thus, a writer who uses AI is not a writer.

A.R. Gowtham

Writery legacy

Nisha da Cunha's writing explored women who were unfulfilled, abandoned or out of step with their circumstances, while her teaching influenced generations of students. ('Nisha da Cunha's heartbreak stories'; Aug. 23) Such literary legacies deserve preservation beyond obituaries. Colleges and libraries could digitise the works of such important regional writers and organise readings around them.

Swathi Senthilkumar

Lack of care

The article highlights how distance, poor antenatal care, inadequate treatment and poverty can cause avoidable deaths. ('When healthcare comes too late'; Aug. 23) Rural healthcare therefore needs more than the occasional medical camp. Primary centres require trained

staff, essential medicines, reliable transport and proper referral systems.

K.P. Muthukumar

Good old days

The article serves as a heartfelt reminder that, as time passes, our perspective of life evolves. ('Another year, another cake'; Aug. 23) Priorities shift, celebrations happen when convenient, and the true depth of our connections becomes more apparent.

Sajna Hameed

Invaluable history

The history of the betel leaf is a useful reminder of the process of cultural absorption. ('The betel leaf's Indian makeover'; Aug. 23) Such examples can help counter narrow ideas of cultural purity. Schools and museums should present more histories of this kind, showing how trade, migration and interaction have continually shaped Indian social and cultural practices.

Prajesh Paramasivan

Art for life

Gautami Reddy has nailed it. ('How to live in the age of A.I.'; Aug. 23) Her guide to living in the age of artificial intelligence is charming precisely because it ignores the tech and points us back to ourselves. The hand-drawn style keeps it warm, never preachy. Simple, tender and quietly necessary.

Rhea

Gautami's artwork resonated so deeply with me because the ultimate resistance to AI is to go back to being simply human. And, at least for now, that is beyond its reach.

Mahathi



MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

Biting into culture

Food is one facet of culture and dish names are sometimes riddles

P.K. Misra

Yardsticks for progress

Should civilisation be evaluated on the basis of the betterment of thought process and tolerance?

N.S. Venkataraman

The loneliest generation

The problem begins when convenience replaces human interaction, and instant consumption replaces reflection

Kiran Sogali

A bird for a friend

Earning the trust of a rooster and the unfolding of a tragedy

M.A. Krishnaprasad

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(L-R) Anamika Khanna; sculpted couture from Tarun Tahiliani's 'Ang'; a red bridal look from 'Moonlit Palace'; singer Billie Eilish; and TT's outfit with the belly button outlined. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND GETTY IMAGES)

Shweta Shiware

Anamika Khanna gave a man a backside. Not a metaphorical one or a clever cut of trousers, but a proper, rounded, emphatic backside, a few inches behind him.

He wore a sharply cut jacket, tailored close through the shoulders and chest, over trousers that disappeared beneath the sudden swell of fabric at the back. The look was part of 'Moonlit Palace', which opened this year's Hyundai India Couture Week. His body hadn't changed, just the silhouette. "We created bustles, like how the Victorian bustles were created," says Khanna. "Sometimes you use boning, and where required, metal." She'd sell the look as shown if anyone were brave enough to wear it. "It opens up Pandora's box after that," she says.

Tarun Tahiliani followed days later with 'Ang', a conceptual exploration of the human form through sculpted couture. His intervention went further: sculpted abs, an emphatic hip, a fuller torso, an answer of sorts to the bewilderment over what the body is supposed to be. Each form was individually sculpted from layers of foam in an R&D room, then dressed in satin, lace, and, in one look, Kanjeevaram. He wanted the effect to feel "hard and soft, almost like marble or stone". He was, as he put it, acting like a plastic surgeon through clothes.

Manufacturing a body

The idea had been taking shape since January. At Tahiliani's 30th anniversary show, a detachable boned 'tashreef bustle' enlarged the hip. 'Ang' went further: padding beneath the clothes widened the hip and carved the abdomen.

In New York, Tahiliani had noticed a body ideal he found increasingly narrow. His

SHAPE OF THINGS TO COME

From Dior and Rei Kawakubo to Anamika Khanna and Tarun Tahiliani, designers have used padding in different ways to reshape the body

answer was to alter the silhouette rather than ask the wearer to alter her body. "Everyone's become too thin, too fit. You can be curvaceous, you can be Indian, you can have abs if you want," he says. Some looks had them, some didn't.

This puts his padding inside a much longer history of manipulating the silhouette. "Today people use shoulder pads for bigger shoulders, stuffed bras to enhance the bust, butt pads for a fuller shape," he says. "We've always done it in history, with the bust and the farthingales that were in the West. Not so much in India, where the drape expects curves and usually finds them."

A history of padding

Padding has done one of two things: made the body agree with power or disagree with everything. Shoulder pads did the former. Elsa Schiaparelli brought padded shoulders into fashion in 1931, borrowing from American football; by World War II, structured shoulders signalled women stepping into wartime work. The 1980s turned them into shorthand for authority, from British Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher to French designers Thierry Mugler and Claude Montana.

Christian Dior shifted the emphasis lower. After years of mending coats and rationing fabric, the French designer's



(Clockwise from left) Tarun Tahiliani; singer Ariana Grande; a cream bustle look from 'Moonlit Palace'; the Dior Bar Suit; and Khanna's model with a "backside".



1947 Bar Suit padded the hip and let the skirt fall full, abundance made visible after scarcity. The Metropolitan Museum of Art (MET), which has an original suit in its Costume Institute, specifies that the haircloth interlining shaped the contour. On Dior's Chérie dress, thirteen-and-a-half yards of fabric were compressed into the seam. The MET's 2001 'Extreme Beauty' exhibition traced the same instinct across centuries: bodies constricted, padded, truncated or extended through panniers, bustles, hip pads, crinolines.

Japanese fashion designer Rei Kawakubo ruptured that construction in 1997. Her 'Body Meets Dress, Dress Meets Body' collection padded the hip, rear and belly into strange, lopsided forms – "lumps and bumps" designed to disrupt rather than flatter the body. Magazines shot the same garments with the pads quietly removed.

India had its own version. Actresses including Sadhana and Asha Parekh wore what women in the 1960s called "fake bottoms" under tight saris. The sari draped better over a shape the body didn't have. Set against this history, Tahiliani's 'Ang' reads less as invention than escalation. His foam reshaped the body until the silhouette read almost like an X-ray.

The body under scrutiny

This loosening of fixed codes lands at a moment when the body itself is under surveillance. American singer-songwriter-actress Ariana Grande stepped back from public life this year amid intense scrutiny over her thinness; singer-songwriter Billie Eilish said years earlier that a big shirt gave her "relief" from a body she'd had a "toxic relationship" with.

Looksmaxxing, the online pursuit of a sharper face through jawline exercises, extreme diets and, in some cases, self-inflicted injury, has

brought a familiar body anxiety into men's lives. An Indian innerwear brand sells a padded vest that sculpts the chest and biceps for a few hundred rupees.

Khanna, however, is not interested in answering that anxiety with another ideal. Asked whether Ozempic or the body conversation was behind her volume, she says she has stopped thinking about it. "If you're too big, it's not okay; if you're too thin, it's not okay. I'm letting it go. To each their own," she says.

Her volume comes from several histories. There's bridal tradition: brides who "feel that if they are bigger in volume, they stand out". There's the men's bustle, borrowed from war-era dress, and the Victorian silhouette itself, where volume could dictate how a woman stood, moved and even sat. Khanna kept the volume without prescribing the posture; hers was provisional, worn or not depending on the person and occasion.

There's Kalighat too, the 19th-century Bengal painting tradition of satirical, puffed-up men and voluptuous women. "Sensuous without being afraid," is how she explained it. The show's opening look featured a female model in a moustache, nodding to maharajas who once dressed as women in private. "Right now, it's acceptable. So why should I hide it?" asks Khanna. Her bustle nodded to a language in which gender could be played through dress, posture, manner.

Dior used padding to make scarcity look abundant. Kawakubo used it to make the body strange. Tahiliani used it to construct a fuller one; Khanna used it to ask what volume could do. None needed a different body. Just different padding. For a while, anyway.

The writer is a columnist and critic, with a keen focus on fashion, textiles, and culture.

Many years ago, before my frontal lobe had had a chance to peak, I decided to enter the world of crime – theft to be precise. I was seven and a half, and we were spending the summer at Phuphee's. It was hot and most of our time was spent running around the orchards, often trying to seek the shade of an obliging tree.

On one such hot day, the criminal mastermind in me was awakened, probably by the confusion caused by dehydration and listlessness. I had been walking around trying to find my cousins in a game of hide and seek, when I saw a *kraenjul* (wicker basket) resting by the window in the pantry. Inside was a bunch of juicy crimson red plums. I looked around and could see no one. So I reached out my sweaty little hand and grabbed one and devoured it, the blood red juices running down my chin and frock.

When I had consumed one, I grabbed another and then another, dropping the pits to the floor. Before I could gather my senses, I had consumed half a dozen. I would have eaten more, but my stomach rebelled. I heard a sound

coming from the kitchen, and in a tizzy I picked up the pits in my hand and buried them in the ground. I believed it was the perfect crime.

I walked to the front of the house, where Maetonji (Phuphee's friend and the nun who ran the local hospital) was sitting. She was reading something to Phuphee, who looked like she was sleeping. As I got closer, it became clear that Phuphee was indeed fast asleep, but Maetonji kept reading *Little Women* to her. This scene was confusing. I didn't know Phuphee could try to find my cousins in a game of hide and seek, when I saw a *kraenjul* (wicker basket) resting by the window in the pantry. Inside was a bunch of juicy crimson red plums. I looked around and could see no one. So I reached out my sweaty little hand and grabbed one and devoured it, the blood red juices running down my chin and frock.

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ILLUSTRATION: ZAINAB TAMBAWALLA



A LITTLE LIFE

The plums I stole

A handful of pilfered fruit and a lesson from Phuphee about being fully seen, and loved

Count Dracula so much! Ta-hee-era never sleeps, she closes her eyes, but she can still see and hear everything. It's part of being a great and powerful *peerni*.

Upon hearing this, I was dumbstruck. Had Phuphee seen me eat the plums? My career as a great thief had

ended before it had even had a chance to blossom, not to mention just how much trouble I would now face. Everyone would know I was a thief, a petty thief who stole plums, plums Phuphee had plucked for *aer tchetin* (a sweet-and-sour plum chutney) for the evening meal. Now there weren't

enough plums to make the *tchetin* for everyone. Blood rushed to my cheeks and I felt great shame.

"Oh Gub-ree-la [Maetonji's name was Sister Gabriella], what new yarns are you weaving in her head now?" Phuphee asked, yawning and stretching.

"Goodness Ta-hee-ra, I am a woman of God. I am sure I don't know anything about weaving yarns. And speaking of God, I need to get back, Lord's work needs doing," she said, as she winked at me. She left the book on the verandah and bid us goodbye.

"Are you alright, *myoan toath* [my loved one]. You look a bit flushed," Phuphee asked.

I didn't have the courage to confess my crime or how deeply sorry I was. So, instead, I embraced her, inhaling the aroma of cardamoms and cloves, and I sobbed.

At dinner as everyone was eating, one of my cousins asked where the *aer tchetin* was. I froze, expecting Phuphee to reveal my crime. She looked at me, meeting my gaze for a split second before replying, "They weren't ripe enough. Maybe in a day or two we can have them," and carried on eating.

Later on, lying next to her in bed, my body nestled in the space between her chest and arms, her breath soft, she stroked my hair and whispered, "You can always tell me anything, *myoan shoosh* [my lungs]."

You will never get into trouble for telling me the truth, no matter how bad it is.

Tomorrow, we will go together and pick more plums for the *tchetin*. With those words I fell into a dreamless sleep.

That incident stayed with me and in moments when my darkness emerged, her unfaltering love became my saving grace. At such times, I understood the importance of being loved wholly, because often the first step towards redemption was acceptance of your own dark side. The most powerful thing about being loved like that, when the darkness in you is accepted in the same way as the light, is you find the strength to never give in.

Phuphee taught me not to just accept both sides of myself, but that light often exists in the same place as darkness. As important as it was to reverse the light, it was also important to be in mild awe of the darkness.

Saba Mahjoor, a Kashmiri living in England, spends her scant free time contemplating life's vagaries.

